

ONE DEAL TO STEAL THEM ALL

LEARN HOW TO GO ABOUT MINING FOR KILLER DISCOUNTS AND SCHEMES AND HOW TO GAME THE SYSTEM TO KEEP YOUR WALLET HAPPY.

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The human proclivity for deals and bargains stems from the same kind of evolutionary conditioning that makes the literal act of hunting release a heady mix of feel good chemicals. It's little wonder why the universally popular act of scouring the markets for great deals is described as bargain hunting. Because like the bloody and visceral practice of hunting, the act of scoring an excellent deal triggers the same sort of satisfaction associated with outsmarting and overpowering prey. No matter how civilised we get, the atavistic instincts ingrained in our lizard brain will always reward the act of dominance, which also applies to dominance of the economic kind.

It's one thing to joke about women and their almost pathological addiction to sales, but at the end of the day it's a phenomenon rooted in reality for both genders and not just an exaggeration. The extent of its economic ramification is apparent when you pay attention to the raw numbers. According to a 2009 Harvard Business report, women earn \$18 trillion annually the world over. Incred-

ibly, they end up spending a whopping \$28 trillion. This is as great a validation of the effectiveness of sales as it can get. And it's not just the women either. Take one glance at the spending habits of geeks and the way Steam discounts mercilessly drub poor gamers' wallets, and you'll realise that men aren't all that immune to the arresting guiles of sales.

It becomes even harder to resist this sales business, when every single online retailer worth its salt bombards ridiculously attractive deals across every conceivable product category on newspaper, TV, and internet. But like a good hunt, scoring a genuinely great deal (as opposed to one that looks good only on paper) isn't as easy as it seems. The odds are stacked against patrons in a casino, and online retailers are no different. Most discount schemes offered don't make much monetary sense once you work out the mathematics. Just like a casino, the only smart and calculated hustlers have the means to beat the system. This guide is intended at getting you, the consumer, up to speed with all the information you need to transform you from the proverbial sheep to a veri-

table hustler dreaded by the Flipkarts and Amazons of the world.

TIMING AND ECONOMIES OF SCALE

Your chances of finding good deals increase dramatically once you get the timing right. The anatomy of a discount is largely dependent on the economy of scale. Larger the number of buyers, slimmer the margins that the seller can afford to sustain, which in turn translates into greater discounts. That means, you're more likely to find killer deals during major festivals, where everyone from the online retailers to product manufacturers themselves are keen on pushing out their inventory at generous discounts. But before you go about buying products just because they are priced attractively, it's your cue to slam the brakes and ask yourself a few pertinent questions.

GOING MOSSAD: PLAN EVERYTHING

For starters, do you want the product or do you need it? More often than not, we are suckered into buying cool gadgets